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CASE 5 · CA DESIGN LAB · NEW

△ CASE

Second Thought

Sustainable buying decisions, with an agent

ONLINE SHOPPING IS BUILT FOR ONE CLICK.

Can an agent help people make more sustainable buying decisions, without patronising them?

Clothes, electronics and furniture are chosen online in seconds, in shops built to make buying easy. AI shopping assistants now advise us, and some even buy for us. Many people say sustainability matters to them, yet the moment of buying rarely reflects it. Our own study, currently under review, found that a more human-like shopping chatbot alone did not change what people were willing to pay for more sustainable products.

PRACTICE

- Large retailers run AI shopping assistants in their apps; some can complete a purchase.
- Since 27 September 2026, generic green claims need proof (EU Directive 2024/825).

RESEARCH

- Persuasive agents for sustainability: buying decisions are a blind spot (Strohmann et al., 2024).
- Defaults work far better than information alone (Ixmeier & Kranz, 2024).

USERS

- Anyone who buys online. Your team picks a group and a product domain.
- The hardest and most interesting group: people who do not care about sustainability at all.

OPEN QUESTIONS

01 Why do good intentions disappear at checkout?

02 What would make someone pause, without feeling patronised?

WHAT YOU GET

- Three core papers and further sources
- A summary of our own study, currently under review
- A starter pack: a mock product page, what we know, a dilemma



YOUR SUPERVISOR

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